

so cut off from the local people and never so dependent on the court of St. James in London. That was part of the reason they evolved a different, more decentralized system of government with more emphasis on individual rights and limited central power. And it's probably why there was never any popular uprising against them.

Lesson? If you want to keep your head, keep your feet on the ground. Stay close to your roots, your base, and your family stronghold. You need roots, a sense of being connected, a refuge from the outside world, a place where your family is safe and sure of itself. As our old friend Gary North says, you need a place where you can "dig in."

Today, very few families can survive on their own. In developed countries, there are few subsistence farmers left. Very few people could live for more than just a few days if the sophisticated system of production and distribution were interrupted. Yet it seems very unlikely that the system won't be disrupted.

War, revolution, Internet bugs, real bugs, bankruptcy, hyperinflation—there are so many things that could go wrong, it is hard to believe that at least one of them won't.

In light of this, you should have a place where the family can run, hide, and survive. Where? The best place is a farm—a place not too far from where you usually are, easy to get to, and stocked with enough food and water to keep you going for a few months. Best bet is an old-fashioned pantry full of canned goods, chickens in the hen house, and a pig or two in the sty.

Here in Maryland, your editors have not completely followed their own advice. They have a country house in Maryland, for example. But they have no animals. And they have never gotten around to stocking anything more than firewood and wine. How long can you survive on Bordeaux? We don't know, but in case of a total breakdown, we intend to find out.

Does this sound alarmist? Paranoid? Nutty?

Maybe. We are so accustomed to thinking that everything will work out fine. It always has, at least in our lifetimes. But everything doesn't always work out fine. There are, remember, a few black swans as well as many white ones. Those black swans can be nasty. And it takes only one to wipe you out.